

AI governance among AI-using businesses

How commonly businesses report formal or informal AI policy or guidance.

Policy or guidance point estimates rise from 20.1% for micro AI users to 29.0% for small and 36.8% for medium AI users.

Evidence scope

Table 50 describes businesses that already report using AI technologies. The measure is a net for formal or informal policy or guidance; it does not assess quality or effectiveness.

UKBDS Official source DSIT 2026	95% Uncertainty Intervals retained	SMEs Primary scope Large shown separately
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Executive summary

20.1% Micro AI users 17.3-22.8%	29.0% Small AI users 23.8-34.2%	36.8% Medium AI users 27.8-45.7%	67.7% Large benchmark 58.1-77.2%
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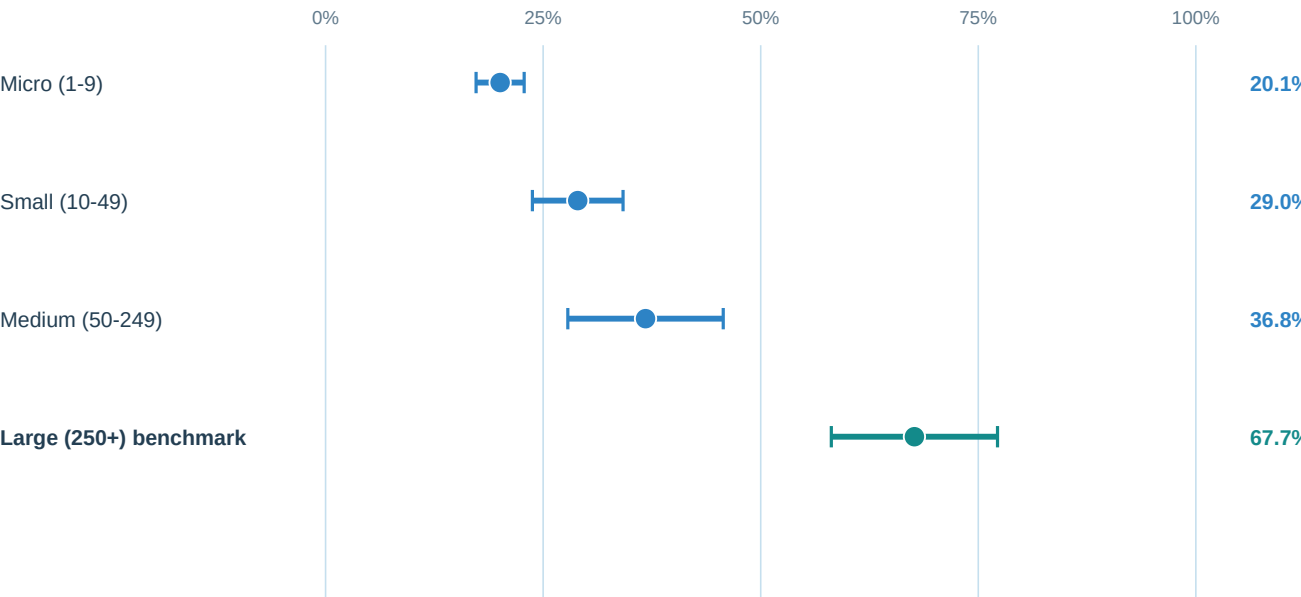
The published point estimates increase with business size. Even so, the survey measure only shows whether any formal or informal policy or guidance is reported - not whether it is complete, used or effective.

Formalisation differs by size The micro-business point estimate is the lowest and the medium-business point estimate the highest among SMEs.	Many AI users report no policy/guidance The reported net remains below 40% for each of the three SME groups.
Presence is not quality The source does not evaluate coverage, enforcement, staff awareness or outcomes.	Governance should fit the business A proportionate approach can start with clear responsibilities and decision rules rather than a large policy manual.

Governance is an operating discipline, not a document count. The survey supplies a baseline for asking better questions.

Evidence by business size

Point estimates among businesses already using AI, with supplied 95% confidence intervals.



Business size	Estimate	95% interval	Rounded base
Micro (1-9)	20.1%	17.3-22.8%	960
Small (10-49)	29.0%	23.8-34.2%	350
Medium (50-249)	36.8%	27.8-45.7%	130
Large (250+) benchmark	67.7%	58.1-77.2%	100

These are conditional estimates for AI-using businesses, not percentages of all UK businesses.

Decision use: six proportionate governance questions

The following are practical discussion prompts, not additional survey findings.

1. Ownership Who is accountable for permitted uses, exceptions and unresolved risks?	2. Data What information may or may not be entered into AI tools, and why?
3. Human review Which outputs require checking before they influence customers, staff or financial decisions?	4. Transparency When should colleagues or customers be told that AI supported a process or output?
5. Incidents How should errors, unsafe outputs, data leakage or vendor changes be reported and handled?	6. Monitoring Which uses, outcomes and complaints should be reviewed periodically?

Useful interpretation

- The increasing size pattern is a reason to segment governance support, not evidence that larger firms have better governance.
- Policy presence and system integration should be reviewed together, because connected workflows can increase operational consequences.
- A short, role-specific set of rules may be more usable for a small business than a generic enterprise policy.
- Later research should test sector regulation, data sensitivity, customer impact and workforce practices.

Method, interpretation and source trail

These reports retain the survey definitions rather than treating every percentage as directly comparable.

Source and fieldwork

Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, UK Business Data Survey 2026. Fieldwork ran from 10 October 2025 to 28 January 2026. Source tables used: Table 50.

Denominator

UK businesses within each published business-size category that report using AI technologies.

Uncertainty and bases

The official central estimates and supplied 95% confidence intervals are shown. Unweighted sample bases are rounded respondent counts, not counts of UK businesses. The medium and large groups generally have wider intervals because their bases are smaller.

Interpretation limits

- The findings are descriptive. They do not establish causation or business impact.
- The published package does not provide the covariance, replicate weights, raw microdata or official pairwise method needed for a fully defensible size-group significance test.
- Large businesses are a separate benchmark and are not part of the primary SME result.
- The net combines formal and informal policy or guidance.
- The measure does not assess governance quality, completeness, enforcement or effectiveness.

Official material

[UK Business Data Survey 2026 publication](#)

[UK Business Data Survey 2026 technical report](#)

Use this evidence as a disciplined starting point for questions and prioritisation - not as a substitute for organisation-specific assessment.